



THE ABSENCE OF A FOURTH FRONTLINE SEAMER INDICATES INDIA IS EXPECTING THE BALL TO TURN IN THE SUPER 8 STAGE IN THE WEST INDIES

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It would be pragmatic to label India and Pakistan as the favourites to progress from Group A at the upcoming Twenty20 World Cup in the West Indies and the USA.

However, on May 10, with less than a month to go for T20 cricket's biggest extravaganza, former American

football defensive end J. J. Watt's famous words - "Success isn't owned, it's leased. And rent is due every day" - may have come as a rude awakening for Pakistan, the 2009 champion and last edition's runner-up.

Meeting each other for the first time in the shortest format after 15 years, Ireland registered its first win in men's T20Is over a full-blooded Pakistan squad in the first clash of a three-match series in Dublin.

Although Pakistan won the remaining two fixtures, would the team deal with the loss as a mere glitch in the matrix? After all, the two sides are set to go up again in a

month's time at Lauderhill, Florida, on June 16.

From Zimbabwe edging Australia in 2009 to Namibia beating then Asia Cup defender Sri Lanka two years ago, the T20 World Cup is no stranger to upsets. Given the single round-robin format of the group stage, even one win against the odds can prove to be decisive. So, there will be no room for complacency.

How late is gracefully late?

And obviously, there are bigger worries for Babar Azam's men — for starters, there's no knowing who they are until Pakistan plays its T20I series opener against England on May 22. Going into a marquee tournament, it is imperative to strategise months ahead with a core 11 in mind. As Ramiz Raja said on his YouTube channel, it does seem like "Pakistan are stuck. They can't handle the combinations. Every

player is on trial".

The individual performances in Dublin are bound to confuse the selectors further.

Former pacer Umar Gul's nephew, 23-year-old Abbas Afridi, may have finished with six wickets, the second-most successful in the series after leading paceman Shaheen Shah Afridi, but he conceded 112 runs off the 71 balls he bowled.

Naseem Shah and Mohammad Amir took four wickets combined and leaked runs at a touch below 10 an over. Hasan Ali, who replaced Naseem in the third T20I, gave away 42 runs in three overs without taking a single wicket.

In the batting department, left-handed opener Saim Ayub appeared clueless. He averaged 21.66 in the series, while Babar and Mohammed Rizwan were left to do the heavy-lifting again.

Once the squad is finalised, the biggest challenge awaits Pakistan on June 9 when it meets archrival India, presently the No. 1 T20 side, at the Nassau County International Cricket Stadium in New York.

Well-rounded

Hardik Pandya, who captained Rohit Sharma in the 2024 Indian Premier League, will return to being the latter's deputy in India's blue.

The top-order of India looks mostly settled, with Rohit and Yashasvi Jaiswal set to open. Batting mainstay Virat Kohli follows. However, it wouldn't be that bad an afterthought to have Kohli open alongside Rohit and get Sanju Samson to come in at three.

The middle order will have the big-hitters in Suryakumar Yadav, Rishabh Pant, and Hardik Pandya.

In the bowling department, Rohit has opted for a spin-heavy approach, with Ravindra Jadeja, Axar Patel, Kuldeep Yadav, and Yuzvendra Chahal in the 15-member squad.

The absence of a fourth frontline seamer indicates India is expecting the ball to turn in the West Indies when the tournament rolls over to the business end. This also indicates Hardik, a fast-bowling all-rounder,